N.R. NARAYANA MURTHY
Founder and Chairman Emeritus, Infosys

SUDHA MURTY
Author, Philanthropist, Chairperson of the Murty Trust and Rajya Sabha Member

A '70s ROMANCE

For the Murthys, life is all about learning and improving. Sudha Murty, who is stepping into a new chapter in her life as a nominated member of the Rajya Sabha, puts it thus: "for learning, age no bar". It comes as no surprise then that it was the love of books that first brought the two of them together. The couple who inspired writer Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni's 2023 publication, *An Uncommon Love: The Early Life of Sudha and Narayana Murthy,* were introduced by a mutual friend in Pune in the mid-1970s. "I knew the only hope I had of impressing her was with my impressive array of books," reminisced Narayana Murthy. Among the unusual authors in his collection was the Hungarian-British humorist George Mikes. "She was very much impressed by George Mikes, not so much by me. And that was good enough for me," he quipped.

In those early days of courtship, they would often meet at a fruit juice shop called Darshan, where she would order a "queen-sized orange juice" and Murthy would settle for a "king-sized banana milkshake".

Life, however, was to change drastically once Murthy started Infosys in 1981. "Building a company is not a joke. It requires a lot of sacrifice and support from the family," said Sudha. The famous Infosys anecdote from that period was how she gave her husband Rs 10,000 from her savings to start the firm. "The only investment I made in life is Rs 10,000," she said.

Murthy, the "incorrigible idealist", however, was firm about not running his new company as a family-run organisation as was the "standard [practice] those days". So, he didn't make Sudha a part of the start-up team, "even though she was much more qualified than all the founders". The hurt she felt then, Sudha said, remained for a couple of years. "But when I look back in life now, it's good I did not become a part (of Infosys)... I touched many lives through Infosys Foundation and I value it much more than any other position," the philanthropist said. As Murthy put it, "she always got the first rank, in 10 semesters of her engineering, and at IISc Bengaluru... she was the first woman [engineer] to go to TELCO. Therefore, I had no doubt in my mind that she was truly the better half." ■

MESSAGE TO YOUNG COUPLES

When you are married, you are bound to fight. No. 1, accept that. No. 2, when one person is upset, the other should be cool....you should never get upset together because that is a recipe for further fights. The third thing is, life is about give and take. There is no perfect life, no perfect couple... No. 4, all men in this generation should help their wives in the kitchen

Sudha Murty

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Sudha Murty and Narayana Murthy bonded over books after being introduced by a mutual friend in Pune**
- **Sudha gave Murthy Rs 10,000 from the Rs 10,250 she had saved for emergencies, to start Infosys. She kept the remaining Rs 250 for a rainy day**
- **Sudha Murty was a gold medalist both in engineering college and later at the Indian Institute of Science where she did her Masters in Computer Science. But Murthy was firm about not making Infosys 'a husband and wife company', It was, as he put it, an act of idealism**